East Asia and [the] Far East and to Japanese militarism and expansionism."[114]

But India was not willing to jettison its US relationship. Delhi needed Washington less, but the US remained important—and not just from the security perspective. Swaran Singh, who once again headed the foreign ministry, noted that the US continued to be India's "most important partner in the economic field."[115] Moreover, its military and economic relationship with its other partner—the Soviet Union—was not without trouble, especially given deepening Soviet-Pakistan relations.[116]

Thus Gandhi sent L. K. Jha to Washington as ambassador, asserting, "India's relations with the United States should be as good as they are with the Soviet Union." Jha, however, worried about American indifference and whether and where India still fit into the US strategic framework.[117] Assistant Secretary of State Joseph Sisco admitted to him that US-India relations were at a "delicate point."[118] Harking back to an earlier age, the Indian foreign minister urged Jha to highlight the China-India contrast as "a common basis for India and America to work together."[119] The days when that worked, however, were gone.

The US: Juggling China, India, and Pakistan (1970)

In 1970, the Nixon White House continued seeking to establish relations with Beijing. In January, the two countries announced a resumption of the Warsaw talks. That spring, Nixon stated in his foreign policy report that it was in American interest to "take what steps we can toward improved practical relations with Peking." Officials debated whether to send a representative to China, but the American invasion of Cambodia put Sino-US engagement on ice. After the US withdrawal from Cambodia later that summer, both sides took further steps that signaled the process was back on track. Earlier, the White House had used the Pakistan channel to send messages indirectly. Now, Nixon and Kissinger used the channel to indicate directly to Beijing that they wanted talks and normalized relations.[120]

Nixon did not intend for US relations with China and India to be a zero-sum game. Even as relations with China were improving, the administration was careful about handling potential irritants in the US-India relationship. One such problem, in spring 1970, was the Indian closure of foreign